

a plan to balance spending with income.

Others who are not in debt also need a budget. Why? Because it's also a plan for controlling spending. A budget should help determine where to cut back to develop a surplus. It's that surplus that God is able to use both to enhance your lives and His work.

I'll next help you go through a typical budget, item by item, to determine how much should fit into each category. I would suggest that you read through this entire section before you attempt to develop a budget. After you have finished this next section, refer to Appendix B as your guide.

11 ESTABLISHING A BUDGET

In this section, we're going to look at the "how to" side of handling money in the home—more specifically, how to develop a budget. Remember that a budget is nothing more than a plan for how you're going to handle your money over the next year. As I said earlier, it's crucial in talking about a budget to remember that it is a plan for managing *all* of your money over the next year. We're going to divide it into monthly segments, because most families handle their money on a month-by-month basis.

If I were a pastor, which I am not, I would never marry a couple who had not first developed a budget, showing me how they were going to spend their money over the next year. Once they had done that, I would assign them to an older couple in my church who would then meet with them once a month for the next 12 months to ensure that they were living on their budget. After 12 months, they would know how to manage their money properly. By just doing that one simple thing, we would make the vast majority of new marriages secure.

Without a doubt, a budget will restrict your freedom. As I said earlier, it's a lot of fun to get into debt. In fact, there's practically nothing more fun than getting into debt. However,